CINEMA ▶

Showing the *Mirror*

Actress Pallavi Joshi's latest film—*The Bengal Files*—explores the partition of Bengal, which she feels hasn't been represented enough in mainstream Hindi cinema



PTI

"Art needs to also disturb people," says National Award-winning actress Pallavi Joshi. "We somewhere felt that we can make that happen." She is talking about her collaborations with her husband, writer-director Vivek Agnihotri, whose works *The Tashkent Files* and *The Kashmir Files* have done just that—ruffled feathers, created heated socio-political discourses and turned dramas into communal big-screen experiences. The couple is hopeful that their September 5 release, *The Bengal Files*, part three of the *Files* trilogy, does the same. Says Pallavi, "I have looked at my profession as something more than being an entertainer. It is about giving back to society. We want audiences to sit up, look around and think [of] what's happening in India."

In doing so, Vivek and Pallavi have popularised politically charged, controversial narratives rooted in both India's distant and immediate past. "If you





FESTIVAL ▶

DISRUPTIVE CINEMA

Selections at the *Emami Art Experimental Film Festival* show that, if you have patience and passion, budgets are secondary

"I don't teach experimental cinema to my students; I encourage them to experiment." These moving words by American experimental filmmaker Leighton Pierce guided Indian filmmaker Mehdi Jahan as he curated 15 Indian and 27 international films out of 1,100 submissions for the fourth *Emami Art Experimental Film Festival*. To be held in Kolkata from September 11 to 14, the festival encourages "alternative practices in moving image-making".

According to Jahan, who also teaches at Kolkata's Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute, he has observed a resistance "to experimental cinema within the majority of Indian film schools, where the instructional framework predominantly favours narrative cinema... which stifles the possibility for students to develop their own language of cinema."



Welsh filmmaker Scott Barley, whose iPhone-shot *A Ladder* is part of the official selection; top-left, Rushnan Jaleel and a still from his experimental film, *The Dithering Veil*

For example, Mumbai's Rushnan Jaleel, whose *The Dithering Veil* is an official selection, has been experimenting with film since he was 16. "The solitary handcrafted nature of Stan Brakhage and Phil Solo-